STYLE GUIDE · VERSION 1.6

Nebuloria style guide

The rules behind the typeface, in numbers, so that icons, ornaments, frames and layouts can speak the same language as the letters.



Companion to the Nebuloria Design Book. Units are font units (1000 per em, x-height 500) unless stated otherwise.

1 · STROKE MODEL

A broad nib at 45°

Nebuloria is drawn as if with a **broad-edged pen held at 45°**. Strokes moving from top-left to bottom-right are heavy; strokes moving from top-right to bottom-left are hairlines. Apply the same model to every drawn line on the site.

PROPERTY	VALUE	RULE OF THUMB
Pen angle	45° (edge NE–SW)	Thin along NE–SW, heavy along NW–SE
Lowercase stem	≈ 112 (x-height 500)	stem ≈ 0.22 × x-height
Capital stem	≈ 125–130	≈ 1.15 × lowercase stem
Hairline	≈ 13	stem ÷ 8
Contrast	≈ 8 : 1	thick : thin
Tendril	≈ 11	≈ stem ÷ 10, constant width

Optical size for icons and ornaments

DRAWING SIZE	MAIN STROKE	HAIRLINE	CONTRAST
24 px icon	2.5 px	1 px (minimum)	≈ 2.5 : 1
48 px icon (grid 48 × 48)	5 px	1 px	≈ 5 : 1
96 px and up	size × 0.11	main ÷ 8, ≥ 1 px	8 : 1
Diagrams, 600 px	≈ 12 px	≈ 1.5 px	8 : 1

Hairlines never go below 1 CSS pixel; contrast is reduced at small sizes rather than letting hairlines disappear .

Mirrored weight

Every main stroke comes in a **stroke pair** with a thin **tendril**. Both start at the same point. Their weight profiles mirror each other:

STROKE	PROFILE
Main stroke	Full weight for the first ≈ 80% of its length, then tapers to a needle point or a hairline tail.
Tendril	Hairline for ≈ 85% of its length, then swells into a small teardrop (≈ 3 × tendril width).

Terminals

TERMINAL	WHERE
Needle point	Free ends of main strokes, spurs
Hairline tail	Feet, along the baseline, longer to the right
Teardrop	End of every tendril and wire
Chamfered flag	Top-left of capitals and entry spurs, cut at 45°
Leaf	Only inside closed counters; never on top



The F: heavy stroke, tendril alongside, teardrop at the end, chamfered flag at the top-left, asymmetric foot.



The leaf grows from the inside of the bowl into the counter.

Where the weight moves



The lowercase s, g and e are the reference letters for construction: watch how the weight travels through each stroke.

The weight travels. In the s the heavy part runs diagonally through the spine (top-left to bottom-right) and thins into hairlines where the curve turns. The g and e show the same: heavy where the pen moves NW–SE, hair-thin where it moves NE–SW.

Straight, then turn. A curve first runs straight and only then bends; the turn is where the stroke becomes thin.

Round and cut, each in its place. Bowls may stay round where the weight flows (s, g, e); a 45° cut is used where a stroke ends or meets a corner (the terminals of the s and e, the ear of the g). Never a perfect circle, never a soft blob.

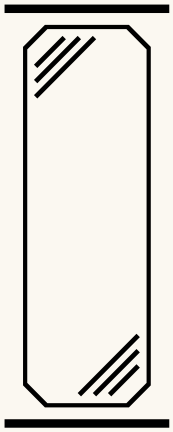
One direction. Diagonals and curls only travel north-east to south-west.

Asymmetry. Feet are longer to the right; stroke ends finish in sharp chamfered points.

Applying it to frames, dividers and vines

ELEMENT	RULE
Frames and corners	Straight frame, corners cut at 45° (≈ 1/4 of the shorter side).
Dividers	Hairline swelling into a heavy centre, needle points at both ends.
Vines	Heavy stem with a tendril alongside; turns go straight-then-turn.

The window and the wire





WINDOW PART	VALUE
Bridges (x-height, baseline)	10 thick, hairline
Pane outline	5, inset 14, corners cut 26 at 45°
Glare lines	3 × 45°, lengths 34 / 52 / 70, width 5
Position	top-left and bottom-right of the pane

The **window** is a pane of glass and a circuit seen through clear plastic. Use it as a picture frame, a card or a callout: hairline frame, chamfered corners, three glare lines, nothing else inside.

The **wire** hangs like a liana: from the top-right of one element, a soft round U-curve, into the top-left of the next, ending in a teardrop. Use it to connect steps on a route; never straight, never angular.

Roles and sizes

ROLE	USE	SIZE	FEATURES
Wordmark	Names, logos, signatures	80–160 px	`dlig` on
Display headings	Titles, section heads	36–96 px	`dlig` off, or on from 72 px
Pull quotes	Short lines, closing words	30–60 px	`dlig` on
Iron fence	Single words, very large	96 px and up	Hekwerk style, or `ss01` on
Big numbers	Stats, dates, prices	30–60 px	lining figures; tendrils may reach into the neighbour
Text and UI	Not for Nebuloria	–	pair with a calm text face

Pairing

Nebuloria is the one expressive moment per page. Everything that needs to be read is set in a calm, neutral text face. Never set Nebuloria in all caps for more than two words, and never track it out.

Hekwerk

Use the Hekwerk style (or `ss01`) only for single words at large size, where the iron fence is the point.

Recent work

A calm text face for what needs to be read, Nebuloria for what needs to be felt.

Keep it precise

Do

- Grow ornament from the stroke: tendrils, leaves inside counters, wires between elements.
- Cut corners at 45° and let the stroke thin at the cut.
- Keep hairlines ≥ 1 px and contrast ≈ 8 : 1 at large sizes.
- Use one window or one wire per composition.

Don't

- Add flowers or leaves on top of lines.
- Use chrome, gloss, gold, bevels or drop shadows.
- Draw perfect circles or soft round blobs.
- Use uniform, monolinear strokes for ornaments.
- Set Nebuloria below 30 px or for running text.

Say it precisely

Nebuloria was made by directing AI image models with words. These are the words that worked. Use them exactly; vague mood words ("magical", "organic", "techy") make a model drift to clichés.

TERM	MEANS
Centre line	The path of a stroke, without thickness. (Avoid "skeleton" for this: it suggests a heavy frame.)
Stroke	All thickness laid over the centre line, heavy and thin, plus its ends.
Broad nib at 45°	Strokes top-left to bottom-right heavy, top-right to bottom-left hairline.
Hairline	The thinnest stroke, about 1/8 of a stem.
Stroke pair	A heavy stroke plus a thin wavy tendril starting at the same point.
Tendril	Monolinear wavy hairline that swells into a small teardrop at its end.
Taper	A heavy stroke running out into a needle point or hairline tail.
Chamfer	A corner cut straight at 45°.
Chamfered flag	The 45°-cut entry at the top-left of capitals and stems.
Counter leaf	A small sharp leaf growing from inside a closed bowl into the counter.
Window	Shared counter between two stems: hairline bridges, chamfered pane, three 45° glare lines.
Wire	A round hanging liana-cable from one letter's top-right into the next letter's top-left.
Glyph sheet	One row of separate letters with wide gaps, for tracing.
Ruler letter	A known letter (H or n) at the start of a sheet of new signs: it fixes baseline and height, and is not built.
Composite	An accented letter built from the font's own letter plus one drawn accent; never redrawn.

Words need balance: always say how much and where. "Chamfered corners" means everywhere; "at most one" tends to mean none.

Start here

This is an AI prompt for an image generator (for example ChatGPT, Midjourney or Gemini). It recreates lettering in the style of Nebuloria, or something very close to it: for new letters, a logo, a title or a variation. Copy it, replace [LETTERS] with the letters or word you want, and attach one or two images of Nebuloria letters as references.

> **Tip:** take a screenshot of the font (for example from the design book) and ask the AI to use that font. A reference image is worth more than any description.

```
A glyph sheet for the display typeface Nebuloria. Solid black letterforms on a
plain warm off-white background, flat vector look: no colour, no texture,
no 3D, no shadow, no guide lines, no labels.

LAYOUT: one single horizontal row of separate letters on one baseline, all the
same size, with a wide empty gap between every two letters. Nothing touches,
nothing connects letters to each other. The row shows: [LETTERS]

STROKE: razor-sharp, crisp edges. Extreme contrast, as if drawn with a
broad-nib pen held at 45 degrees: strokes from top-left to bottom-right are
heavy, strokes from top-right to bottom-left are hairlines (about 1:8).
Every free end tapers to a needle point or runs out into a hairline tail
along the baseline. Never blunt, never soft rounded blobs.

CONSTRUCTION: a curve first runs straight, then turns; the stroke becomes
hair-thin where it turns. Corners and stroke ends are cut at crisp 45-degree
chamfers; bowls where the weight flows stay round (like s, g and e).
Diagonals and curls only run north-east to south-west.
Serif feet are asymmetric, longer to the right.

CAPITALS: every main stem is a stroke pair: a heavy stroke with a thin wavy
monolinear tendril alongside it, starting at a chamfered top-left flag and
ending in a small teardrop.

LOWERCASE: heavy straight stems, hairline tails along the baseline, a small
sharp-pointed leaf growing inside every closed bowl (a b d g o p q),
a small chamfered diamond dot on i and j.

STYLE: Victorian cast-iron-and-glass conservatory meets Y2K translucent
futurism; elegant solarpunk. Botanical, not floral.
Avoid: colour, fairy-tale vine lettering, leaves stuck on top of strokes,
flowers, blackletter, art deco, gold, metallic effects.
```

When it goes wrong

Models rarely get it right in one shot. These were the most frequent problems while making Nebuloria, and the follow-ups that fixed them.

PROBLEM	CORRECTING PROMPT (ADD TO THE BASE PROMPT)
Drifts into fairy-tale vines, turns green, leaves sit on top	*"Black only. No storybook or fairy-tale vine lettering. Leaves only inside closed counters, growing from the stroke; nothing added on top of strokes; no flowers."*
Strokes look soft, blunt or blurry	*"Copy the stroke sharpness of the reference exactly: needle-fine points, hairline tails, crisp 45° cuts. Never blunt or rounded ends, no blurry edges."*
Chamfers everywhere: letters turn octagonal or blackletter	*"Chamfer only the top-left flag and the corners where a stroke ends. Bowls where the weight flows stay round, like the reference s, g and e."*
A letter looks too basic, not part of the family	*"Apply all family techniques: broad-nib contrast at 45°, crisp chamfered flag, needle-sharp ends, asymmetric tapering feet and, for capitals, a tendril alongside the heavy stroke."* Name approved letters as the standard.
Round where it should be cut, or cut where it should flow	Say exactly where, e.g. *"the arch leaves the stem as a straight 45° hairline, runs flat, then drops through a crisp chamfered shoulder into the heavy stem."*
Wires come out straight, angular or as spikes	*"The wire is a smooth round hanging liana: from the top-right of the first letter, a soft U-curve, rising into the top-left of the next. Tendril thickness. Never straight, never a V."*
Windows too heavy or too many, letters unreadable	*"Hairline bridges, a hairline pane outline, no filled corners, at most one window per word; every letter must stay readable."*
Wrong letter identity (q as g, l as i, t as f, F as E)	Describe the defining trait: *"q is a mirrored p with a straight stem on the right; capital I has no dot; t has a short stem and a crossbar; the F's foot is short on the right."*
Letters touch, so they cannot be cut apart	*"A wide empty gap of at least half a letter width between letters; nothing touches."*
Adding a detail makes the model redraw the whole letter	Render the existing letters in light grey and ask: *"keep the grey letters exactly; add only the [detail] in pure black."* Then extract the black.